COLLABORATIVE DISCUSSION 2: INITIAL POST

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Unit 10

Machine Learning

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This article is a straight reminder of how fast the AI field evolves. What Hutson calls "AI" is, more precisely, a large language model (LLM) (Hutson, 2021). The capabilities Hutson describes for GPT-3, such as writing songs, stories, essays and code from a prompt, have progressed in five years into new frontiers: OpenAI's GPT-5.5 plans, uses tools and finishes multi-step tasks with little guidance (OpenAI, 2026).

LLMs began as remarkable writers, and today, through the explosion of agents and by taking advantage of their evolved generative fluency, they now power automation and decision-making, from email drafting and creative work to customer service. ChatGPT reduced professional writing time by 40% and improved quality by 18% in one experiment (Noy and Zhang, 2023). But Hutson's stated risks remain: toxic outputs, bias, dangerous advice and privacy leakage, amongst others. One area that interested me and took me into wider reading beyond this module is that we use an LLM's text generation to simulate cognition where true cognition does not really exist. There is a perception of reasoning, but not true cognition. This gap between simulated and actual reasoning generates a risk that may have unforeseen consequences. Yejin Choi, referenced in Hutson (2021), describes LLMs as "a mouth without a brain", whilst Apple researchers showed that "reasoning" models look convincing but are challenged as more complexity is introduced (Shojaee et al., 2025).

Drawing a parallel with social media impact on brain development, we are seeing evidence of potential harm now, many years after becoming pervasive (Maza et al., 2023; Xiao et al., 2025; Haidt, 2024).

So, if the expansion of LLMs through agentic use is becoming a pervasive technology in the palm of our hands, what happens to our brain development when you outsource the cognitive ability to an actor that does not have such capabilities? Reuters reports that technology leaders AI spending is set to hit USD 600 billion this year (Reuters, 2026), but is society mature enough to decouple the business from responsible use, and to evaluate it critically, even when that may imply a pause in development?

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